University of Jena
Department of English and American Studies
Winter 2016-17

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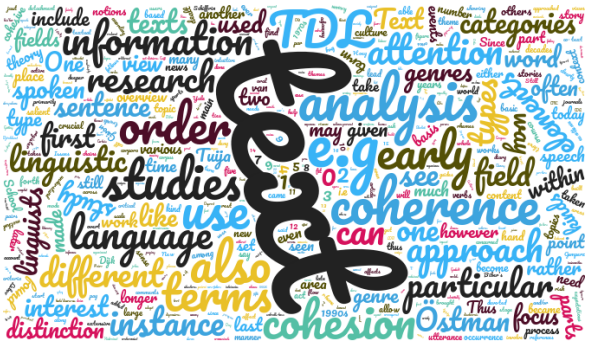
Text and Discourse Linguistics



BA.AA.SW05
Tuesday, 10 - 12 am
August-Bebel-Straße 4, SR 117
5 ECTS

Seminar Description

> *A text is a 'finite ordered set of textually complicated partial signs of various sorts and functions' and hence 'the linguistically significant originary sign of language'.*
>
> (Hartmann 1968)

> *A text is a polyphonic composition in which different semantic melodies are interwoven, to be realized as integrated lexicogrammatical structure.*
>
> (Halliday, 1975)

While linguistics has developed most sophisticated tool kits for the analysis of language on the levels of morphemes, words, phrases, and sentences, comparatively little work has been done on longer stretches of language. This seems all the more surprising since in everyday life – e.g., in newspapers, internet, emails, small talk – language is used not in the form of single words or sentences but in the form of text and talk. A text encompasses all other lower linguistic levels and yet is not just a bunch of words and sentences strung together but a complex collocation of forms and meanings, as the quotes above emphasize. This seminar aims at introducing students to the discipline of Text and Discourse Linguistics which is concerned with the analysis of the 'semantic melodies' and 'integrated lexicogrammatical structure(s)' which keep a text together. In particular, students will learn about and practice to analyze the lexicogrammatical, rhetorical, and informational structure of texts. Moreover, they'll learn to distinguish between genres, text types, and registers and gain insight into their roles in research. Last, students will have a look at the cognitive processes underlying text comprehension and the interdependence of discourse, cognition, and society. A final note: While Text and Discourse Linguistics is part of academia and not training for the job, the knowledge and skills you'll acquire in this seminar relate to many fields of work, e.g., print and online journalism, advertisement, first and second language teaching, publishing, doctor-patient talk and diagnosis, translation, and human-to-machine communication.

Addressees

This seminar is aimed at B.A. and teacher students of English who have completed the module Introduction to Linguistics and M.A. students of economic education ('Wirtschaftspädagogik').

Date	Topic	Preparatory reading	Homework
04-04-2017	Text as a multifaceted phenomenon		
	On genre, text type, and register		Send me a question (50-100 signs) about one paper from each of the six key topics. Write what troubled you about the paper, what you thought was particular good/bad, etc. Altogether, you need to write six questions. Some of your questions will be discussed in class. The questions are due on Sundays before class.
04-11-2017	Grasping what they are	Trosborg (1997)	
04-18-2017	Applying them to data	Biber and Egbert (2016)	
	On cohesion and coherence		
04-25-2017	Learning what keeps a text together...	Halliday and Hasan (1976)	
05-02-2017	... in different languages + practicing	Schubert (2016)	
	On rhetorical structure		
05-09-2017	Discovering rhetorical structures,...	Mann and Thompson (1988)	
05-16-2017	and how to analyze and visualize them[a]	Taboada (2006)	
	On information structure		
05-23-2017	Becoming well-informed about (the) topic	Fery and Krifka (2008)	
05-30-2017	Patterns of information across genres	Lorés (2004)	
	On cognition		
06-06-2017	Boggled Bublitz on coherence and cognition	Bublitz (2006)	
06-13-2017	Framing	Bednarek (2005)	
	On a final note		
06-20-2017	Meeting Critical Discourse Analysts	Wodak (2011)	
06-27-2017	The example of antisemitism in Germany	Schwarz-Friesel (2015)	
07-04-2017	On writing a seminar paper	Schmidtke-Bode (ms)	

[a] PC pool, room 1100, Carl-Zeiss-Straße 3

Requirements, weekly preparations and grading system

Your grade will depend on a seminar paper (submission deadlines 09-29-2017 and 11-30-2017). Moreover, to be admitted to the seminar paper, a visible commitment to the seminar (continual and active participation, etc.) and weekly preparation in the form of readings and accompanying homework will be required. In addition, you'll need to participate in one of the expert groups (see below).

Expert groups

For each of the six key topics, a group of students will find and prepare a sample of text and/or discourse which we'll use for analysis and discussion in class. They'll be responsible for finding and preparing appropriate samples in time, they'll support their co-students analyzing the material, and they'll play a prominent role in the discussion of the results. Come to my office hours sufficiently early to discuss what kind of material is needed.

The course management system

You find readings and materials on the online platform of our department, WORDWISE. Important information on the organisation of the course will also be distributed via WORDWISE (to your email address). Please enroll in this seminar on WORDWISE (the password was announced in class) and stay updated.

References

Bednarek, Monika A (2005). "Frames revisited—the coherence-inducing function of frames". In: *Journal of pragmatics* 37.5, pp. 685–705.

Biber, Douglas and Jesse Egbert (2016). "Towards a user-based taxonomy of web registers". In: *Variational Text Linguistics: Revisiting Register in English.* Ed. by Christoph Schubert and Christina Sanchez-Stockhammer. De Gruyter, pp. 19–41.

Bublitz, Wolfram (2006). "It utterly boggles the mind: Knowledge, common ground and coherence". In: *Language and Memory. Aspects of Knowledge Representation.* Ed. by Hanna Pishwa. De, pp. 359–386.

Féry, Caroline and Manfred Krifka (2008). "Information Structure: Notional Distinctions, Ways of Expression". In: *Unity and diversity of languages.* Ed. by Piet van Sterkenburg. John Benjamins, pp. 123–136.

Halliday, Michael Alexander Kirkwood and Ruqaiya Hasan (1976). *Cohesion in English.* Routledge.

Lorés, Rosa (2004). "On RA abstracts: from rhetorical structure to thematic organisation". In: *English for specific purposes* 23.3, pp. 280–302.

Mann, William C and Sandra A Thompson (1988). "Rhetorical structure theory: Toward a functional theory of text organization". In: *Text-Interdisciplinary Journal for the Study of Discourse* 8.3, pp. 243–281.

Schmidtke-Bode, Karsten (ms). "Practical Guidelines for Writing a Paper in Linguistics". online. Jena.

Schubert, Christoph (2016). "Cohesion in contrast: A case study of English and German user manuals". In: *SKY Journal of Linguistics* 29, pp. 95–117.

Schwarz-Friesel, Monika (2015). "Using Language as a Weapon: Verbal Manifestations of Contemporary Anti-Semitism". In: *The Exercise of Power in Communication. Devices, Reception and Reaction.* Ed. by Rainer Schulze and Hanna Pishwa. Palgrave MacMillan, pp. 162–183.

Taboada, Maite (2006). "Discourse markers as signals (or not) of rhetorical relations". In: *Journal of pragmatics* 38.4, pp. 567–592.

Trosborg, Anna (1997). "Text Typology: Register, Genre and Text Type". In: *Text typology and translation.* Ed. by Anna Trosborg. John Benjamins, pp. 3–23.

Wodak, Ruth (2011). "Critical Linguistics and Critical Discourse Analysis". In: *Discursive Pragmatics.* Ed. by Jan Zienkowski, Jan-Ola Östman, and Jef Verschueren. John Benjamins, pp. 50–70.

Note: I reserve the right to alter this syllabus (dates, readings, assignments, et. al.) during the semester when I deem it necessary.